

BOOKS OF ACCOUNTS IN *EVERYMAN* AND *ELCKERLIJC*

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Kolve has argued strenuously that the semantic field of accounting which is so prominent in *Everyman* should not be ascribed 'to the dramatist's unique invention' and that it is in fact a traditional metaphor which was commonly used in relation to the Last Judgment.¹ Nevertheless, the many references to the book of accounts in *Everyman* and its Dutch original, *Elckerlijc*, seem to have led some scholars to assume that these references carry commercial, mercantile overtones which can tell us something about the authors and audiences of these texts.² Although the idea that the book of accounts can tell us something about the social status and mindset of the author and/or the intended audiences is exciting and, at first sight, plausible, a close look at the references in *Elckerlijc* and *Everyman* indicate that using the book of accounts to identify the social background of the play is misleading. By exploring the verbal and theatrical presence of these items in the two plays, I aim to establish a clearer sense of their significance.

When discussing the books of accounts in these plays, I will rely on one important assumption, namely that *Elckerlijc* and *Everyman* were both intended for performance. There is considerable scope for doubt here as both texts are extremely ambiguous on this point: the Dutch printed text carries the tag *Hier beghint een schoon boecxken, ghemaect in den maniere van eenen speele ofte esbatement op elckerlijc mensche* ('Here begins a pretty little book, made in the manner of a play or *esbatement* [short and/or comic play] on every man') and the English title page states 'Here begynneth a treatyse ... and is in maner of a morall playe'.³ Is this a play text being presented as a book or a book being presented as a play? I shall assume that these texts were play texts, even if their primary distribution was probably in print rather than on the stage, because the various adaptations of *Elckerlijc*, including *Everyman*, consistently adopt the dramatic mode and at least some of these adaptations were performed.⁴ We have no evidence of either *Elckerlijc* or *Everyman* themselves being performed until the twentieth century. As a result, any discussion of what might or might not have happened on the fifteenth or sixteenth century stage is necessarily

conjectural and it is worth bearing in mind that different productions would almost certainly have staged things differently, if these texts were staged at all. Nevertheless, using the texts and representative contemporary sources we can try to arrive at a better understanding of the appearance and function of the book of accounts in these texts. I shall also, as has already become clear, follow the widely accepted theory that *Elckerlijc* is the original and *Everyman* a relatively faithful translation.⁵ The dates proposed for *Elckerlijc* vary quite widely: Vos pushes the play back into the early fifteenth century but most editors place its date of composition nearer the first surviving print of 1496.⁶ The play evidently remained popular into the sixteenth century. The date of the *Everyman* translation is also unknown but its first surviving printed edition dates from c.1508–1528; three further editions are datable to roughly 1525–1535.⁷

It is worth pointing out that the book of accounts is not the only type of written document to which these plays refer and that it might not have been the only kind of text to be represented by a prop on the stage. If these other documents were also visually represented, then the book of accounts was only one of the text-props and presumably did not stand out significantly; if these other texts were not physically present on the stage, the book of accounts prop would have been a more unique focal point.

Towards the end of the play, for example, the protagonist makes his testament: ‘For I wyll make my testament | Here before you all presente’ (697–8; *Ick wil gaen stellen mijn testament | Voor u allen hier in present* 651–52). He then goes on to specify what should happen with his goods. It is possible that these lines were accompanied by the actor performing the writing of a testament; Middle Dutch *stellen* is often connected with ‘putting in writing’ although it can also mean ‘ensure, clarify, make certain’. But if there was writing action on the stage, this action was not exploited to any great degree as there is no reference to any physical document, ink, or writing implement; we can perhaps assume that the testament was not represented by a physical prop.

Elckerlijc also refers to the Book of Life, which was generally believed to be God’s list of names of the saved: Revelation 20: 15 *et qui non est inventus in libro vitae scriptus missus est in stagnum ignis* (‘and whosoever was not found written in the book of life was cast into the pool of fire’) and Paul’s letter to the Philippians 4: 3 which refers to *adiutoribus meis quorum nomina sunt in libro vitae* (‘my fellow labourers, whose names are in the book of life’). When *Elckerlijc* is praying before commencing his penance, he

exclaims: *Scrijf mi int boeck des Hemels blade* ('Write me in the pages of the Book of Heaven' 552). The Book of Life seems to have been a relatively common feature in medieval thinking on death and the Last Judgment. We find various illustrations of it, such as the angel holding an open codex, which contains some writing, standing beside God in the Last Judgment tympanum at Conques.⁸ Both the angel and the devil carry a (seemingly blank) codex in the so-called Winchester *Liber Vitae* — and it is encouraging to note that the angel's volume seems to be the thicker.⁹ Margery Kempe recalls how she saw an angel 'beryng an howge boke befor hym' in which she saw 'the Trinite, and al in gold', a book which the angel announced to be the 'Boke of Lyfe'.¹⁰ Although this gives us a good idea of how a contemporary would have imagined this Book of Life, it is perhaps unlikely that it was present as a prop during a performance of *Elckerlijc* because the reference to the Book of Life is only a passing one in a long prayer for salvation. On the other hand, Ramakers argues for a *tableau vivant* with the Trinity and Mary on a raised level during *Elckerlijc*'s prayer before his penance.¹¹ If this was indeed the case, and given that there is an angel later in the play, it may be that there was an angel holding the Book of Life flanking God.

Despite the familiarity of the Book of Life, the English translator seems to have been somewhat confused by this line, and we find a much more obscure 'yet let my name be wryten in Moyses table' (596) in *Everyman*. This would seem to refer to the Tables of the Ten Commandments although the text has the singular noun rather than the expected plural. The Laws of God may well lead to salvation — indeed, N.Town's Moyses recommends 'his lawys of lyff ... to lerne, be dyligent, | Youre soulys may thei save at the last asyse' (6: 56–8) — but this hardly explains Everyman's wish to have his name inscribed on Moses' table.¹² Wood calls upon Berthold of Chiemsee's *Tewtsche Theologye* to explain this reference: the first table of the Ten Commandments was taken to stand for baptism, the second for penance.¹³ This does not entirely explain the use of 'Moyes table' in *Everyman* either, because, although Everyman is about to undertake physical penance through scourging, he is at this point clearly not so much occupied with either baptism or penance, as with salvation:

Though I be a synner most abhomynable[,]
 Yet let my name be wryten in Moyses table.
 O Mary, pray to the Maker of all thyng,
 Me for to helpe at my endyng.

595–8

The Dutch original is similarly concerned with salvation at this point:

*Al bin ick sondich, mesdadich ende quaet,
 Scrijft mi int boeck des Hemels blade,
 Want ic begheer aen u ghenade.
 O Maria, moeder des hemels Almachtich,
 Staet mi ter noot bi voordachtich.* 551–5

‘Even though I am sinful, criminal, and bad, write me in the pages of the Book of Heaven, because I desire mercy from you. Oh Mary, mother of almighty heaven, stand carefully by me in need.’

Moreover, it is questionable whether a relatively obscure German theological tract — it was written in 1528 and translated into Latin in 1531 but does not seem to have circulated widely until the nineteenth century — is the best support for an interpretation of *Everyman*. Cooper and Wortham give a further reference to Lydgate’s *Pilgrimage of the Life of Man*. However, in Lydgate’s text Moses’ table seems to refer not to stone tables but to an item of furniture, presumably referring to the altar in the tabernacle as described in Exodus 40, where the pilgrims go to get ‘gostly foode’ rather than to have their names inscribed.¹⁴ Moreover, Moses ‘gaff yt [the spiritual sustenance] with-out exception, ... To pylgrymēs good & badde’ (5118–20). It is not very likely that *Everyman* is in some round-about way asking to be allowed to approach this particular table. However, in Exodus Moses seems to mention the Book of Life shortly after breaking the stone tables: *aut si non facis dele me de libro tuo quem scripsisti cui respondit Dominus qui peccaverit mihi delebo eum de libro meo* (‘Or if thou do not [forgive the idolaters], strike me out of the book that thou hast written. And the Lord answered him: He that hath sinned against me, him will I strike out of my book’: Exodus: 32: 32–3). Perhaps this explains the slightly confusing line in *Everyman*.¹⁵ Until a better interpretation can be offered for this puzzling reference, I would suggest that whereas the Dutch *scrijft mi int boeck des Hemels blade* (‘write me in the pages of the Book of Heaven’ 552) conjured up images of a book of some sort, probably held by an angel, the English ‘yet let my name be wryten in Moyse’s table’ (596) most likely conjured up an image of stone tables and possibly confusion in the minds of the readers and/or spectators. As with the Dutch play, the phrase is part of a longer prayer and not elaborated upon, and as such there do not appear to be strong grounds for assuming that ‘Moyse’s table’ was represented as a prop of some kind, although the possibility that it was must remain.

Kolve warns readers not to confuse the accounts frequently mentioned in the play with the Book of Life because the accounts of the protagonist are kept on earth whereas the Book of Life is kept in heaven.¹⁶ He is quite right to stress this difference, although the overlap between the two is greater than he allows. We occasionally see the heavenly book in connection with the struggle between angels and devils over a soul. For instance, in the stunning Hours of Catherine of Cleves, which is dated around 1435–1460 and was made in the Low Countries — and which is therefore relatively close in time and geography to *Elckerlijc* — the angel and devil are shown fighting over the Book of Life.¹⁷ This suggests that the notion of the Book of Life starts to be confused with the account metaphor. The Book of Life is something that can be used to weigh you up. This confusion, indeed, is already present in the Bible. Revelation 20: 12, for instance, implies that one's deeds are listed:

Et vidi mortuos magnos et pusillos stantes in conspectu throni et libri aperti sunt et alius liber apertus est qui est vitae et iudicati sunt mortui ex his quae scripta erant in libris secundum opera ipsorum

And I saw the dead, great and small, standing in the presence of the throne. And the books were opened: and another book was opened, which was the book of life. And the dead were judged by those things which were written in the books, according to their works

This sounds very similar to

And loke thou be sure of thy rekenynge,
For before God shalte thou answer and shewe
Thy many badde dedes and good but a fewe. 106–8

and

*Want ghi moet voer God Almachtich
Rekeninghe doen, des seker sijt ...
Van uwen wercken, goet ende quaet.* 90–3

‘Because you must before God Almighty give a reckoning, be certain of this ... of your works, good and bad’.

Still, the Book of Life is a heavenly composition, whether it contains a list of names or a more detailed account of an individual's life, whereas Everyman's book of accounts, it is stressed at various points in the play, is an earthly composition.

The distinction between the book of accounts and the Book of Life, which Kolve argues for, thus seems to stand in the plays. The reference to the Book of Life (and Moses' table) in the penance scene is a passing one and probably without visual support on stage. And although it is, of course, possible that the angel welcoming the soul of the protagonist held some sort of book-prop (as in the Conques Last Judgment tympanum), there is nothing to suggest that this was the case. Indeed, in the angel's speech at the close of the play there is a specific reference to the accounts ('Thy rekenynge is crystall clere' 898 and *Haer rekeninghe is puer ende reyne* 851) which makes it improbable that the angel is also carrying a Book of Life or Moses' stone table referred to in passing much earlier in the play. The fleeting references to Everyman's testament and the Book of Life (or Moses' table) are important in confirming the idea of the text as a dominant shaping image in the plays, but it is probable that unlike the book of accounts they were not physically represented on the stage. Even if they were, the many references to the book of accounts in the plays ensure that it is this document which attracts most attention.

Despite the fact that these accounts are frequently referred to in the play and were almost certainly intended to be present as a stage prop, it is not entirely clear what they might have looked like. In the English text there is more emphasis on their being a book of some sort. In the Dutch they are described with more general terms such as *u ghescriften ende u pampieren* ('your writings and papers' 88), *mijn pampier* ('my paper' 116), *mijn ghescrifte* ('my writing' 121), *u rekeninghe* ('your reckoning' 454); the English translates all these with 'book of account' or 'book of reckoning'.¹⁸ They are also called *mijn brieven* ('my letters' 506) in the Dutch. However, *pampier* was also used to refer to books, particularly registers and such-like non-literary artefacts, and *brief* similarly could refer to a little notebook. We are therefore probably dealing with a variety of documents in the Dutch play; at first sight, the English version indicates that only one book is meant to be present on the stage but the use of the plural in 'loke the bokes of your workes and deeds eke, | Beholde how they lye under the fete' (503–504) demonstrates that there is also confusion of number here.

Given the lack of specific details and consistent information concerning the book of accounts in the two texts, contemporary art may give a better sense of the kinds of documents to which these words would most probably have referred. In an undated 'Death and the Miser' painting by Jan Provost (1462/5–1529), for example, there are various books and pieces of paper surrounding the rich man, as with the later Quentin Matsys' 'The

Moneylender and His Wife' (1514). Some paperwork also features in Hieronymus Bosch's 'Death and the Miser' painting (1494 or later).¹⁹ 'The Tax Collectors' by Marinus van Roeymerswaelen (probably 1550) shows more papers more prominently.²⁰ All this relates nicely to the variety of written documents mentioned in *Elckerlijc*; conversely, the more consistent reference to a single book in the English version is not in accordance with the idea of business documents conveyed by contemporary paintings.²¹ However, earlier depictions of moneylenders and business, such as in a manuscript of Augustine's *City of God* from 1478–1480 or in a manuscript of Christine de Pisan's *L'Epistre d'Othea* from 1450–1475, often do not show any papers or notebooks.²² It is likely that papers of various kinds were used in business before they were depicted in works of art and that the references to paperwork in the play would have had overtones of business. But, given that the artistic depiction of papers relating to business does become increasingly prominent towards the end of the fifteenth and in the course of the sixteenth centuries, we have to consider that if *Elckerlijc* was an early play the reference to the books of accounts would perhaps have had fewer secular and commercial connotations for its first audiences than we assume.²³

Just as there is no consistent information about the number and kinds of documents that might have been portrayed, there is a lack of clarity about the writing in the accounts in both plays. At one point, the writing in the accounts seems to be blotted and illegible in the English text ('blotted and blynde' 419), yet *Elckerlijc* in the Dutch version seems to hint that the documents are almost blank because of his lack of charity: *Ic en hebbe noyt goet bedreven, | Aldus heb ic seer luttel ghescreven* ('I have never done any good, thus I have written very little' 165–6). At other points *Elckerlijc* exclaims that there is not a single letter which is without sin or legible (*Men siet hier een letter niet die reyn is* 458), while the English Everyman seems to be staring at a blank document ('For one letter herein can I not se' 507). In the English play, the shift from blotted script to empty page might seem to correlate with the crucial transfer from physical goods to spiritual good. Goods boasts 'Thy rekenynge I have made blotted and blynde' (419) and indeed Everyman has invested too much in his Goods so it seems likely that the 'bad deeds' part of his account would be rather exhaustive. But when Everyman reaches Good Deeds and finally sees the account book itself, he seems to see nothing, which would be an accurate representation of his sheet of good deeds. However, Good Deeds also goes on to lament the illegible state of the accounts ('There is a blynde

rekenynge in tyme of dystresse' 508), so it is not clear whether the accounts Everyman inspects are indeed meant to be blank. Instead, it would appear that the translator somewhat awkwardly left out the adjective *reyn* ('pure, legible') in the protagonist's line (458), ending up with the claim that there is not a letter to be seen. Seemingly uncomfortable with the notion of an empty book of accounts, he then added the extra line for Good Deeds to clarify Everyman's statement — there is no equivalent for that line in the Dutch version. The correlation between a full Goods sheet but an empty Good Deeds sheet in the English version is consequently tentative at best. Neither playwright is entirely consistent on the amount of writing to be found in the accounts and there is no clear sense of a worryingly full 'bad deeds' section and a terrifyingly empty 'good deeds' section, although both writers seem to be toying with that idea.

It is worth noting here that, although this was a time when exciting new developments were taking place in the practice of bookkeeping, it is not clear to what extent double-entry bookkeeping affected trade in the Low Countries in the fifteenth century, or indeed in sixteenth-century England. It is true that Luca Pacioli's treatise of 1494, which included the *Particularis de computis et scripturis* section on double-entry bookkeeping, was translated into both Dutch — Jan Ympyn's *Nieuwe instructie* (Antwerp, 1543) — and English — Hugh Oldcastle's *A profitable treatyce* (London, 1543) — but the impact of the treatise and its translations is difficult to ascertain and, in any case, too late to be of much interest for *Elckerlijc* and *Everyman*.²⁴ It does seem that knowledge of the new system spread not so much through the publication of treatises but through connections with Italian bankers. There was evidently some awareness of it in the Low Countries well before Pacioli's treatise as, for instance, a Milanese bankers' ledger for the Bruges branch of their business for 1438 uses the double-entry system, but it is not clear to what extent the new practice was adopted by local businessmen.²⁵ Indeed, only one London merchant is known to have used the new system in the sixteenth century.²⁶ However, before double-entry accounting was adopted, many medieval accounts did use an intermediary phase in which some, but not all, transactions were recorded twice.²⁷ And even single-entry accounts could have a very similar lay-out to that associated with double-entry bookkeeping: for example, the fourteenth-century Bruges money changer Collard de Marke's ledger had a *me doit* ('he owes me') and *doy* ('I owe') column for his various clients much akin to the double-entry system (although only transactions from the account of one client to that of another are entered twice, once

on the debit and once on the credit side of the respective clients).²⁸ In such an uncertain situation, the contemporary developments in accounting can shed little clear light on the probable lay-out and content of the books of accounts in *Elckerlijc* and *Everyman*.

Overall, there is little reliable information to be found in the texts regarding the appearance of the faulty book of accounts — there may even have been several books of various shapes and sizes on stage which may or may not have contained writing — except that they are discovered in a state of physical disarray when we first see them: ‘loke the bokes of your workes and deeds eke, | Beholde how they lye under the fete’ (503–504; *Siet u geschrifte ende uwe wercken*, | *Hoe dat si hier legghen* 456–7). The disorder of the accounts is clearly indicative of their inadmissible status. Later on, after *Everyman* has done penance, a revived *Good Deeds* brings along the accounts which have now been amended:

Everyman: Good Dedes, have we clere oure rekenynge?

Good Deeds: Ye, indeede, I have it here. 652–3

Elckerlijc: *Duecht*, hebdi ons rekeninghe claer?

Duecht: *Jae ic*, *Elckerlijc*. 611–12

How the accounts were made to look acceptable is unfortunately also not evident from the surviving texts. It may well be that the ‘purification’ of the accounts happened off-stage by substituting one prop for another, since this happens during *Everyman*’s penance. On the other hand, we see *Good Deeds* during the scourging when she announces that she can now walk again, so it is also possible that something happened on *Good Deeds*’ part of the stage to show this purification, perhaps when she says ‘his good workes I wyll helpe hym to declare’ (622; *Oeck sal ic sijn weldaet clarerren* 581).²⁹

Naturally, a special effect on stage at this point would result in more spectacle, but it could also make the powerful spiritual effect of *Everyman*’s scourging visual and would thus not only have dramatic but also doctrinal impact. Although it is possible that *Good Deeds*’ recovery may have been deemed sufficient itself to indicate the effect of *Everyman*’s penance, it seems relatively safe to assume that something may also have happened to the book of accounts to indicate the beneficial effect of penance, given how much attention the accounts have received in the play up to this point and given that they are shortly afterwards presented to the protagonist. But if something did happen on stage to the accounts, there are no clues as to what that something might have been. However, if *Good Deeds* does

carry the books of accounts with her for the remainder of the play, as seems likely — there is no obvious reason or opportunity for Good Deeds to get rid of them and the accounts are mentioned again at the close of the play — then presumably she carried around only one volume rather than an assortment of papers (which might be somewhat awkward as there is much more chance of bits of paper falling). Consequently, one plausible hypothesis is that in *Elckerlijc* a gathering of the various bits of paper occurred and that, from here on, the audience saw a single volume; because of the confusion of number in *Everyman* it is less clear how many books would have been on stage in the first place and what would have happened to show their amelioration. But because the physical disarray of the accounts is the main indication of their inadmissible nature in both texts, a neat volume would be bound to point to the account's improved status. In fact, it is interesting to note that the few remaining references to the accounts from this point onwards, even in the Dutch version, are to the singular 'account' rather than a plethora of papers (*Elckerlijc*: *rekeninghe* 611, *rekeninghe* 851; *Everyman*: *rekenynge* 652, *rekenynge* 898, *rekenynge* 914).³⁰ All in all, we can assume that the acceptable accounts were probably represented by a single book. We can perhaps go even further and suggest that a white, bright, perhaps even shiny book would be appropriate, given the semantic field of words such as *clareren* ('to make shiny, etc.'), *puur* ('pure'), *reyn* ('clean, unblemished'); after all, at the close of the play the angel announces: 'thy rekenynge is crystall clere' (898; *haer rekeninghe is puer ende reyne* 851). There is no reference at all to the size of the purified book of accounts but maybe, given *Everyman*'s paucity of good deeds until the very end of his life, we may suppose that it was rather small and slim (and, of course, carrying a small and slim volume for the remainder of the play would also be easier than carrying a huge tome for the actor playing Good Deeds).

What emerges from this analysis of the references to accounting in both plays is that, despite the importance of the book of accounts, the authors do not seem to have had a very specific idea of what an inadmissible book of accounts should have looked like — except that it would be messy — and that their representation of acceptable accounts seems to rely more on purity and brightness than content. Their conception of these accounts is clearly based on aesthetic and moral principles rather than on the practicalities of book keeping. This lack of practical commercial overtones is important because the Dutch *Elckerlijc* has traditionally been seen as an urban text, a product of the middle-class, commercially-inclined

Rhetoricians, largely because of its mercantile flavour. Mercantile or commercial imagery has been used to ascribe other pieces of Middle Dutch literature to an urban, middle-class setting, most notably by Pleij, who has argued strongly that late medieval Dutch literature was a *burgerlijk beschavingsoffensief* ('civic civilizing offensive'), with the Rhetoricians in the vanguard, to promote middle-class mores and ideals.³¹ The Rhetoricians, the prolific late medieval poets and playwrights in the Low Countries, were, after all, primarily middle-class business men.

The TEAMS edition of *Everyman* argues for both an urban and a Rhetoricians' connection:

the play is definitely associated with city life since the story tells of the rich citizen who has forgotten how to receive salvation by sharing with the poor and showing his charity, and we know that Antwerp, for example, had an extensive tradition of Rhetoricians' plays.³²

However, the specifically urban nature of the play may well have been exaggerated in modern criticism. In fact, the references to an urban setting in the play are as good as nil: the only obvious reference occurs when *Gezelschap* ('Fellowship') mentions going to fairs outside town in the Dutch version (*ter kermessen buten der stede* 247).³³ The purported link between *Elckerlijc* and the Rhetoricians seems impossible to prove or disprove. Ischyrius claimed in 1536 that *Elckerlijc* won a prize at a Rhetoricians' competition in Antwerp, but the reliability of this claim concerning a text which was at the very least forty years older is uncertain.³⁴ Obviously, the absence of typical features of sixteenth-century Rhetoricians' plays does not prove that fifteenth-century *Elckerlijc* was not a Rhetoricians' play but the fact remains that there is nothing in the text which characterises it as the work of a Rhetorician.³⁵ Similarly, although the play might well have won the first prize at an Antwerp *landjuweel*, we have no historical evidence for such a competition in Antwerp before 1496.³⁶ Indeed, the possibility that *Elckerlijc* is not the product of the Rhetoricians needs to be taken into consideration much more than it has been. And since it is not certain that *Elckerlijc* is the work of a Rhetorician, its purported connections with the Rhetoricians should not be used as an indicator and even explanation of the text's commercial and mercantile interests. In fact, although they were on the whole middle-class businessmen, the Rhetoricians abhorred the commercialisation of literature. As such, they banned professional actors and writers from their competitions; for instance, there is a specific

exclusion in the invitation to the 1496 Antwerp Rhetoricians' competition.³⁷ And in the sixteenth century Anna Bijns, a female Rhetorician, exclaims: *Mijn leden beven, therte es ontsteldt | als ic Rhetoricam sie vercoopen om gheldt* ('My limbs shudder, the heart is badly shaken | when I see Rhetoric being sold for money').³⁸ It therefore seems unwise simply to ascribe the use of commercial, financial imagery in *Elckerlijc* to the influence of the Rhetoricians.

Indeed, it is also worthwhile noting that — leaving aside for the moment the book of accounts — there is not much emphasis on commerce in the plays. The play is not forthcoming on the nature of the protagonist's occupation: he has clearly loved his wealth too much but there is no information as to how he has acquired it. It is not even so evident that *Elckerlijc* is particularly rich: it is not the scale of his wealth which is stressed, but rather the fact that he has loved his possessions too much, as anyone may whether rich or poor, aristocrat, merchant, artisan, or peasant. This is, I think, important because it allows greater identification of the audience members with the protagonist, although any staging would, of course, have to make some choices that would limit this openness. Incidentally, the English multiplication of where exactly Goods is to be found is much more emphatic about Everyman's riches as it creates an impression of excessive wealth: 'in corners trussed and pyled so hye, | And in chestes ... Also sacked in bagges ... in packes' (394–8): *tGoet* merely seems to complain of neglect in this speech (*in muten* ('locked away') 350, *versockelt* ('neglected') 351, *vermost* ('mouldy') 351, *vervuylt* ('polluted, dirty') 352). Moreover, the only business transaction explicitly to be mentioned in the two texts is simony:

Therefore Saynt Peter the apostle doth saye
That Jesus curse hathe all they
Which God theyr Savyour do bye or sell,
Or they for ony money do take or tell. 755–8

*Hier om dat Sinte Pieter lijdt,
Dat si alle zijn vermaledijt
Die God copen oft vercopen
Ende daer af ghelt nemen met hoopen.* 711–14

This commercial allusion is obviously more indicative of a criticism of clerical abuses than a mercantile interest.

I would not deny the urban character of *Elckerlijc*, which is very plausible indeed as many surviving Middle Dutch dramatic texts which we

can locate seem to have some connection with urban centres.³⁹ I would, however, caution against using mercantile imagery as an argument for an urban, mercantile background and vice versa. For one thing, no one has used these same features in the English version to indicate a middle-class, mercantile setting of *Everyman*. Note the much vaguer ‘aristocratic or mercantile’ in the following, also from the TEAMS edition:

the play reflects an affluent and secure position in the society. It is, in fact, consistent with the kind of society in which the Dutch Rhetoricians’ plays such as *Elckerlijc* were written and produced. As such, it was a play world that was easily adaptable to the English scene, whether aristocratic or mercantile.⁴⁰

And given that Rhetoricians emphatically insisted that art should not be linked to profit, Pleij’s underlying idea that urban, middle-class people were unable to think outside business terms is somewhat simplistic. It is equally simplistic to see mercantile imagery in a play such as *Elckerlijc* or, indeed, *Everyman*, as evidence for a mercantile author and/or intended audience.

Indeed, as Kolve pointed out concerning the semantic field of accounting in *Everyman*, ‘it is language very common in relation to the Doom’.⁴¹ Common, and used by authors who are not particularly urban, middle-class, and/or commercially-inclined. This is true for both the Middle Dutch and the Middle English corpus. A Dutch translation of *Somme le Roi*, the widely read manual of moral instruction, from 1408 advertises how the treatise:

leert ons hoe wij onse rekeninghe maken sullen teghens den grooten rekendach daermen *summam summarum* voor den groten Coninc brenghen moet.⁴²

‘teaches us how we shall make our account for the great accounting day when one has to bring *summam summarum* [the sum of sums] before the great King.’

Jan van den Dale’s *De ure vander doot* (The Hour of Death) of 1516 counsels *doet rekeninghe hier van uwen bedriue* (‘do a reckoning here of your doings’ 213).⁴³ Using landlord imagery, one anonymous writer laments:

*Wi moeten rekenen, die wert ende ic,
van scoude, die hi mi heeft gheborcht;
dies es leden een groet stic.
Om hem te betalen benic besorcht;
eer dat mi die doot verworcht ...*

*Dus heeft mi die wert doen manen,
dat ic mijn rekeinghe moet maken.
Het gheet al buten minen wanen,
i[k] wijste niet eer van deser saken.*

50–60⁴⁴

‘We need to do a reckoning, the landlord and I, of debts for which he stood guarantor to me; because of it there has been a great deal of suffering. I am worried about paying him before death comes to me ... Thus the landlord had me warned that I must make my account. This all took me unawares, I never knew before of these matters.’

In *Het boeck vanden pelgherym* (1486; *The Book of the Pilgrim*) we find *dachuaert hem ter rekeninge ten laetsten doemsdage* (‘summon him to the reckoning of the last doomsday’).⁴⁵ In Dirc van Delf’s *Tafel van den kersten ghelove* (*Table of the Christian Faith*) of c.1404 we are warned that meticulous accounts will be made at the Last Judgment:

Alle dinghen sullen naket ende bloot voir sinen ogen ondeck wesen, ende op die minste minuut voir hem gherekent, ghetelt ende gheweghen werden, ende die uutslach nauwe ghenomen werden.

Book 3, Chapter 50, 105–8⁴⁶

‘All things will be uncovered, naked and bare, before His eyes and in the shortest space of time summed up, counted, and weighed; and the outcome precisely taken down.’

Similarly, the author points out:

hoe banghe dat dan den sondaer te moede sal wesen, als hi voir dese vierscaer is ghepresentiert ende moet reden ende rekenscap gheven vander tijt, dat hi heeft gheleeft ende in sonden toeghebracht. Eerst van sinen guede, dat hem God hadde verleent ende in sonden verteert ende den armen niet meedghedeilt; ende van sinen lichaem, dat hi heeft in gulsicheit, oncuuscheit ende traechheit besmit; ende van sijnre sielen, dat hi van des Godes beelde ende vander Triniteit ghelijc heeft, mit sonden so mismaect, datsi als die doot is ghescaept.

Book 3, Chapter 50, 252–60

‘how wretchedly afraid ... the sinner will then be when he is presented before the judicial court and must narrate and give account of the time which he has borrowed and spent in sin. First of his goods, which God had lent him and [which were] used up sinfully and not shared with the poor; and of his body, which he

has contaminated with gluttony, lechery, and sloth; and of his soul, which he has in the image of God and of the Trinity similarly, so much maimed with sin, that it is shaped as death'

We can therefore assume that the accounting imagery was a traditional metaphor, commonly used in Middle Dutch literature when reminding people of the need to prepare themselves for death and the Last Judgment, regardless of the background of the author and the intended audiences. In Middle English literature, we find similar uses of accounting imagery. For example, Kolve cites Lydgate's worries in his *Testament*:

Age is crope in, calleth me to my grave,
To make rekenyng how I may tyme haue spent
Baryne of vertu, allas, who shall me saue,
Fro fendes daunger tacounte for my talent,
But Iesu be my staf and my potent,
Ouerstreite audite is like tencombre me.⁴⁷

Langland claims that Christ will:

rewarde hym right wel that *reddit quod debet* — *repays what he owes*
Paieth parfitly, as pure truthe wolde.
And what persone paieth it nought, punysshenn he thenketh,
And demen hem at domesday, bothe quyke and dede.⁴⁸

Similarly Grace appoints Piers as 'my procuratour and my reve, | And register to receyve *Redde quod debes* ('pay what thou owest'; Matthew 18: 28) (Passus 19, 260–1). We also encounter the same notion in Mirk's *Festial* ('Pat a man schall zeue acownte þerof, yn þe day of dome', 22:19–20), the *Prick of Conscience* ('acounte streyte and harde | Of alle oure lyf that is frowarde | That we shul yeelde in Goddes syght', 650–2), and *Lancelot of the Laik* ('Wharof that God a raknyng sal craf | At the, and a sore Raknyng sal hafe', 1357–8) to name but a few.⁴⁹

Words like *reckoning* and *account* could have purely commercial or mercantile connotations, but it is clear they are often used with metaphorical meaning and in religious contexts in medieval literature. Of course, the underlying assumption of the uses of *account* and *reckoning* in relation to the Last Judgment in medieval literature is that good deeds and bad deeds can in some way be added up, just as money is counted in commercial accounts — but this is a traditional idea which tells us nothing about the business acumen of the people using it. As such, the mere use of words such as *account* is by no means a trustworthy yardstick with which

to prove the commercial or mercantile background of any given text. It remains to be seen whether the mercantile imagery of the accounts in *Elckerlijc* and *Everyman* can be considered predominantly to be a metaphor for spiritual affairs or whether it points towards more worldly concerns.

It is worth first considering the plays' overall stance on commerce. As mentioned above, the interest in business is limited. We never find out how the protagonist has acquired his wealth although there are broad hints in both texts that his ways of doing so were not always above board. When *Everyman* makes his testament, for instance, he promises to return half of his goods 'there it ought to be' (702; *daer si schuldich is te gaen* 656). *Everyman* is not, however, so much criticised for unsavoury business practices as for not sharing his wealth; that, according to Goods, is why he is in such a bad spiritual state and it is the first thing *Everyman* rectifies in his testament. This implies that the playwrights are not much interested in business per se, but are concerned rather with promoting deeds of charity.

The plays emphasise the notion that it is not wealth which is immoral, but people's abuse of wealth. Goods lectures the protagonist:

But yf thou had me loved moderately durynge [your lifetime]
As to the poore to gyve parte of me,
Than shouldest thou not in this doloure be. 431–3

Maer haddi mi gemint bi maten
Ende van mi ghedeylt den armen,
So en dorfstu nu niet karmen 390–2

There even is a sense that the truly virtuous would withstand its snare. As Goods claims: 'Yf I save one, a thousand I do spyll' (443). This idea is somewhat more prominent in the Dutch version where it is stressed that it is God who has lent *Tgoet* — the English Goods is lent without an agent — as a test:

Ic en bin met u gheleent
Van Gode; hy proeft, claer alst is voer oghen,
Hoe ghi sult in weelden poghen.
Die menighe blijft bi mi verloren,
Meer dan behouden, weet dat te voren. 396–400

'I have been lent to you by God. He tests, that is clear to see, how you will manage in prosperity. Many are lost by me, more than are saved through me, know that beforehand.'

This implies that money itself is not immoral and that it can be used in a morally and spiritually beneficial way. However, the strong emphasis on the many that are ruined by Goods, combined with the dramatic example of the effects of Everyman's dealings with his wealth, ensures that the negative portrayal is still most prominent.

At first sight, the name of the character representing wealth might be thought to contribute to a tentatively positive view of wealth but, in fact, the ambiguity of the name merely highlights how misleading Goods is. Both in the Dutch play (*mijn Goet* 344) and the English play ('my Good' 389), the initial mention of this character is ambiguous as it is not immediately clear that the labels refer to material possessions rather than moral qualities. This ambiguity, of course, enhances the impact of the audience's realisation that the protagonist has been so immersed in his wealth as to forget about spiritual and moral values altogether. The English name of the virtue character, Good Deeds, further underlines this contrast between the two 'goods'; we do not find this in the Dutch version, as the name for the Good Deeds character, namely *Duecht* (Virtue), does not recall *tGoet* (Goods). The ambiguous *tGoet* and *Goods* are used to highlight how far from good the character Goods is; it is not a positive evaluation of the concept, who clearly rejoices in Everyman's suffering and sets off to ensnare more victims. Overall, it seems doubtful that the plays' presentation of wealth is indicative of a more commercially-inclined author and/or intended audience because Goods' negative characteristics are much too strenuously stressed. Moreover, wealth is primarily seen as a moral test: the authors focus very much on what ought to happen to wealth — it ought to be shared with the poor in acts of charity — but are not interested in how it might be acquired. The presentation of Goods is above all religious and moral and does not suggest any mercantile flavouring.

If the plays are indeed not particularly interested in commerce *per se*, it seems likely that the references to the accounts and account books should be primarily seen as a spiritual metaphor. The spiritual nature of the accounts is stressed repeatedly in the texts. Death charges Everyman:

And loke thou be sure of thy rekenynge,
 For before God shalte thou answer and shewe
 Thy many badde dedes and good but a few,
 How thou hast spent thy lyfe and in what wyse

106–9

*Brengt u gheschriften ende u pampieren
Met u, ende oversietse bedachtich,
Want ghi moet voer God Almachtich
Rekeninghe doen, des seker sijt,
Ende hoe ghi bestaet hebt uwen tijt,
Van uwen wercken, goet ende quaet.*

88–93

‘Bring your writings and your papers with you, and look over them carefully, because you must give an account before Almighty God, be clear on that, and [of] how you have spent your time, of your works, good and bad.’

This is reiterated later in the play when Kindred asks him ‘what a count is that whiche ye must rendre?’ (336; *Waer af moetti rekeninghe doen?* 299) and the protagonist answers

*Of all my workes I must shewe
How I have lyved and my dayes spente,
Also of yll dedes that I have used
In my tyme syth lyfe was me lente,
And of all vertues that I have refused.*

338–42

*Van mijnen wercken, om cort sermoen:
Hoe ic hier mijnen tijt heb versleten
Op aertrijc ende met sonden verbeten
Ende wat ic heb bedreven
Den tijt, gheleent ende niet ghegheven.*

300–4

‘Of my works, to speak succinctly: how I have here passed my time on earth and wasted in sin, and what I have done with the time, borrowed and not given.’

The spiritual metaphor seems significantly more dominant than any mercantile origin of the Dutch and/or English text.

It is, however, true that references to accounts and even the physical books of accounts are unusually prominent in these plays. But, as far as we can ascertain, these are also rather general and often non-technical, as we might expect in connection with a metaphor rather than in connection with genuine books of accounts. Occasionally we do encounter some quite pragmatic, accounts-related vocabulary, for instance, when *Elckerlijc* asks *Duecht* to help him close his account (*mijn rekeninghe sluyten* 466) and when *Duecht* promises to help ‘do sums’ (*zommeren* 482) before God. The English favorite expression is ‘to make my rekenynge/accounte’ (511, 344, 580, 610,

865) which also seems to be quite practical; compare, for instance, the eagle's complaint in Chaucer's *The House of Fame*

For when thy labour doon al ys,
And hast mad alle thy rekenynges ...
Thou goost hom to thy hous anoon

652–5

On the whole, however, we are not told that the accounts need to tally, or that Everyman is bankrupt, the kind of imagery one might perhaps expect. Instead, the accounts are 'blotted and blynde' (419), *verweert* ('rotten, spoiled' 377), *onreyn* ('impure' 454). Similarly, particularly in the Dutch, the vocabulary concerning setting the accounts to right is more concerned with purity than mathematics or business. For instance, there is reference to the need to *mijn rekeninghe verschoonen* ('to clean, beautify my account' 307); the English has the more pragmatic 'to make myne accounte' 344. *Duecht* ('Virtue') mentions that, had *Elckerlijc* led a better life, she would have 'purified' (*ghesuwert* 455) the accounts; the English has the more pragmatic 'your book of accounte full redy now had be' (502). *Elckerlijc* asks *Biechte* (Confession), *verclaert mijn brieven* ('declare, prove, clarify, purify, make shiny my letters/notebooks' 506). But the English text has some similar overtones of purity rather than pragmatic business, for instance, when the protagonist asks Goods 'my rekenynge helpe to clene and purifye' (411) and asks Good Deeds 'have we clere oure rekenynge?' (652).⁵⁰ At the end of the play the accounts are 'crystal clere' (898) and *puer ende reyne* ('pure and unblemished' 851). Clearly, whoever wrote these plays was not primarily concerned with genuine books of accounts and the vocabulary does not show an interest in the technicalities of accounting. It is worthwhile pointing out that, contrary to the impression given by most modern critics who stress the mercantile flavouring of the Dutch text more than that of the English text (for example, see the quotations from the TEAMS edition above), the Dutch *Elckerlijc* features even less vocabulary which may be labelled 'pragmatic' than the English *Everyman*. I think it would, however, be going too far to claim that there is a greater interest in the more secular, commercial aspect of accounting in *Everyman* than there is in *Elckerlijc*, given the lack of consistent information about the accounts in either play, and that some of the vocabulary is clearly non-pragmatic in both texts.

There is a good deal of other vocabulary in the texts that can have commercial, mercantile, or financial connotations, but most of it seems also to have been commonly used with more spiritual or 'neutral'

meanings. For instance, when God in the Dutch version recalls how he suffered death *doer tmenschen profijt* ('for the benefit of mankind' 9), he is clearly using *profijt* ('profit, benefit') in a non-commercial sense. And when He claims that things get worse *hoe ic tvolc meer spare* ('the more I spare the people' 21) that is unlikely to be intended to conjure up the financial associations which the verb *sparen* ('to save') had — the word was often used with non-financial connotations of 'to spare, to protect, to allow to live'. Towards the very end of the play we encounter a reference to payment: 'To make my rekenynge and my dettes paye | For I se my tyme is nye spent awaye' (865–6; *Rekeninghe doen ende ghelden mijn scult*. | *Want mijn tijt is schier vervult* 819–20). What at first sight seems quite commercial imagery is actually proverbial; dying was seen as paying nature's debt, as in an *ars moriendi* printed in 1500 Antwerp: *wanneer alstu by middele van der doot sulste hebben betaelt die scult der mensceliker naturen* ('when you, by way of death, will have paid the debt of human nature' 1155–7).⁵¹

The constant overlap between commercial imagery and spiritual concepts in the play is not surprising given its comparison, as Kolve has pointed out, to the Parable of the Talents. The Parable of the Talents is surely one of the most capitalist moral stories ever. This parable concentrates on money, with the lord praising his faithful servants for doubling the number of coins he left in their care. Increasing one's wealth, even if it is through usury, is commended and the man who hid his coin and did nothing with it is chastised for doing so:

Et timens abii et abscondi talentum tuum in terra. Ecce habes quod tuum est. Respondens autem dominus eius dixit ei: serve male et piger sciebas quia meto ubi non semino et congreco ubi non sparsi. Oportuit ergo te mittere pecuniam meam nummulariis et veniens ego recepissem utique quod meum est cum usura. Tollite itaque ab eo talentum et date ei qui habet decem talenta.

And being afraid, I went and hid thy talent in the earth. Behold here thou hast that which is thine. And his lord answering, said to him: Wicked and slothful servant, thou knewest that I reap where I sow not and gather where I have not strewed. Thou oughtest therefore to have committed my money to the bankers: and at my coming I should have received my own with usury. Take ye away therefore the talent from him and give it him that hath ten talents.

Matthew 25: 25–8

The spiritual implications of the financial images of the parable are particularly clear in its context: the parable of the Five Wise and Five Foolish Virgins precedes it and an account of the Last Judgment follows it. In fact, one of the best known medieval images of the Last Judgment also has potent mercantile implications. *Psychostasia*, or the weighing of souls to determine whether they are saved or damned, is reminiscent, amongst other commercial transactions, of moneylenders weighing coins to assess their value (as in Matsys' painting). Indeed, the word *talent* originally referred to a weight measure, then came to be used for a coin, and then became a word for 'spiritual gift or ability', which shows how closely connected the commercial and spiritual are in the Parable of the Talents, in the imagery surrounding the Last Judgment, and in language use more generally. That *Elckerlijc* and *Everyman* make use of such imagery and language without the authors or the intended audiences having any special interest in commerce is entirely plausible.

Even if the use of commercial imagery for spiritual matters was common, as indeed the use of accounts in relation to the Last Judgment was in both Middle Dutch and Middle English literature, an emphatic use of this kind of language and imagery in the plays might still betray an unease at this overlap between commerce and religion, the worldly and the spiritual. However, given that morally good characters use such language and imagery without concern, this seems unlikely to be the case. Nor are the references to accounts such as to promote a more lenient or positive view of business: as demonstrated, the texts betray little genuine interest in the moral implications of wealth or in-depth knowledge of business and accounting. In fact, the references to accounts in the plays appear to be traditional and conservative and to be used unselfconsciously; perhaps modern scholars' interest in them is slightly misplaced. It seems that the authors were more concerned with showing the true nature of penance and the importance of the clergy, than they were interested in accounts or business. This is not to deny that the playwrights may have had commercial connections or interests, or have envisaged an audience with such connections. But this kind of imagery was widespread in the literature of the time, and it is not used in such a way as to indicate a particular origin for the play — any more than the many references to pilgrimages indicate that the author had been a pilgrim. While it is possible that some members of the audiences and some readers did think of the book of accounts in *Elckerlijc* and *Everyman* in business terms, the texts

themselves seem to use the references predominantly as a traditional, spiritual metaphor whose secular, commercial implications are negligible.

Kolve argued, very convincingly, for the importance of the Parable of the Talents for the English *Everyman*, showing that all the accounting business in the play was to be read with this spiritual metaphor in mind. Conversely, scholars have assumed that *Elckerlijc*, because of a supposed interest in riches, business, and city life, was the product of an urban middle-class-businessman-cum-playwright, that is, a Rhetorician; and, in fact, vice versa, have used the supposed Rhetorician origin of the play to account for the commercial and mercantile nature of the text. But it is not certain that *Elckerlijc* was written by a Rhetorician and, moreover, the Rhetoricians' well-attested insistence that literature and profit should not go hand-in-hand highlights the danger of connecting the text's commercial flavour with any Rhetorician background. In any case, *Elckerlijc*'s urban and commercial nature seems to have been overestimated. The accounting imagery used in the text is imprecise when it comes to the physical appearance of the accounts (in both their unacceptable and acceptable guises) and the vocabulary is remarkably spiritual, aesthetic, metaphorical, and even proverbial rather than pragmatic or technical. The influence of the parable and its spiritual metaphor is, I would argue, equally important for the Dutch original. The author of *Elckerlijc*, and indeed the author of *Everyman*, may well have been acquainted with books of accounts but their main interest lay in spiritual affairs, not accounting.

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NOTES

1. V.A. Kolve 'Everyman and the Parable of the Talents' in *Medieval English Drama: Essays Critical and Contextual* edited Jerome Taylor and Alan H. Nelson (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1972) 316–40, at 317.
2. Davidson, Walsh, and Broos, for instance, claim that *Elckerlijc*'s secular aspects make the authorship of the Carthusian Petrus Dorlandus unlikely; 'Everyman' and Its Dutch Original, 'Elckerlijc' edited Clifford Davidson, Martin W. Walsh, and Ton J. Broos (TEAMS; Kalamazoo: Medieval Institute, 2007) 2. Bruster and Rasmussen's introduction stresses the commercial overtones of the phrase 'to give account' for contemporary readers and spectators; 'Everyman' and 'Mankind' edited Douglas Bruster and Eric Rasmussen (Arden Early Modern Drama; London: A&C Black, 2009) 52. Ramakers similarly points out that *Elckerlijc* is an explicit warning against the dangers of trade and industry;

- '*Mariken van Nieumeghen*' & 'Elckerlijc': *Zonde, hoop en verlossing in the late Middeleeuwen* edited Bart Ramakers (Amsterdam: Prometheus, 1998) 25.
3. The citations from the plays are from the TEAMS edition; the translations are mine. Unless qualified, I shall use the English title and character names to refer to both texts; similarly, I do not provide translations into Modern English for the Middle Dutch quotations when the Middle Dutch and Middle English are very close in meaning.
 4. For instance, Macropedius' *Hekastus* was performed by school children in Utrecht in 1538; Davidson, Walsh, and Broos *Everyman and Elckerlijc* 2.
 5. See, for instance, Francis A. Wood 'Elckerlijc-Everyman: The Question of Priority' *Modern Philology* 8 (1910) 279-302, and John Matthews Manly 'Elckerlijc-Everyman: The Question of Priority' *Modern Philology* 8 (1910) 269-77. For a concise summary of the more salient changes by the English translator, see Bruster and Rasmussen *Everyman and Mankind* 63-6.
 6. R. Vos 'De datering van de Elckerlijc' *Spiegel der Letteren* 9 (1965-66) 101-109; *Den Spyghel der Salicheyt van Elckerlijc* edited A. van Elslander (Antwerpen: De Nederlandsche Boekhandel, 1985) x-xi; Ramakers *Mariken van Nieumeghen* 16.
 7. Davidson, Walsh, and Broos *Everyman and Elckerlijc* 14. Bruster and Rasmussen date the first Pynson edition to around 1518-1519; 'Everyman' and 'Mankind' 76.
 8. For the image, see for example: <http://www.aug.edu/augusta/iconography/conques/tympanum.htm>. The writing on the book is not entirely clear (for a close-up, see <http://www.aug.edu/augusta/iconography/conques/tympanum.middle4.html>: the page on the left appears to say *signatur* ('it is sealed'; probably a reference to Revelation 5) and the right, as far as I can make out, *lib* followed by at least one more letter on the top-most line (but not an *e* as the website suggests, as the *e* is rounded), *r* on the middle line (which seems not to contain traces of missing letters), and *te* on the final line. Although it is very tempting to read the whole page as *lib[e]r [v]ite* (for *vita*), this does not seem possible.
 9. <http://www.trin.cam.ac.uk/sdk13/MSS/LastJudge50.jpg>.
 10. *The Book of Margery Kempe* edited Barry Windeatt (Woodbridge: Brewer, 2004) Chapter 85 (368).
 11. Ramakers *Mariken van Nieumeghen* 30-31.
 12. *The N-Town Plays* edited Douglas Sugano and Victor I. Scherb (TEAMS; Kalamazoo: Medieval Institute, 2007).
 13. Wood 'Elckerlijc-Everyman' 292 (see note 5).
 14. John Lydgate *The Pilgrimage of the Life of Man* edited F.J. Furnivall and Katharine B. Locock *EETS ES* 77, 83, 92 (1899-1904) 2:5135.
 15. I would like to thank Sarah Carpenter for this suggestion.

16. Kolve 'Everyman and the Parable of the Talents' 317.
17. <http://www.themorgan.org/collections/works/cleves/manuscript.asp?page=77>.
18. 'Thy boke of counte' (104), 'my boke of rekenynge' (134), 'my countyng boke' (136), 'your boke of accounte' (502), and 'the bokes of your workes and deeds eke' (503).
19. <http://www.lib-art.com/artgallery/2716-death-and-the-miser-jan-provost.htm>;
<http://www.wikipaintings.org/en/hieronymus-bosch/death-and-the-miser-1516>;
and http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/File:Matsys_the_moneylender.jpg
20. http://www.wikigallery.org/wiki/painting_236193/Marinus-van-Roejmerswaelen/The-Usurers,-after-Massys.
21. The one, inconsistent, use of the plural at 503 suggests that the English playwright had no great interest in the physical appearance or even the number of Everyman's accounts.
22. For images of these manuscripts, see
<http://www.kb.nl/manuscripts/iconclass/46B/page/5> and
<http://www.kb.nl/manuscripts/iconclass/46B3>.
23. Of course, even if *Elckerlijc* was an early fifteenth-century text, the play's popularity seems to have lasted into the sixteenth century and by this point the secular and commercial connotations of the book of accounts would have been well established.
24. Basil S. Yamey 'Pacioli's *De Scripturis* in the context of the spread of double entry bookkeeping' *De Computis* 1 (2004) 142–54 at 146–7.
25. J.L. Bolton and Francesco Guidi Bruscoli 'When did Antwerp replace Bruges as the commercial and financial centre of north-western Europe? The evidence of the Borromei ledger for 1438' *Economic History Review* 61 (2008) 360–79 at 367. Bruges was, at that time, still the commercial centre of the north, although the importance of Antwerp was very much on the rise. Unfortunately, few 'native' accounts for either city survive from the fifteenth century so it is not clear how widespread the use of double entry bookkeeping would have been; 361.
26. This is Thomas Gresham's account book for 1546. Thomas Gresham might also have been responsible for the publication of an English translation of Ympyn's book, *A notable and very excellent woorke* (London, 1547); Yamey 'Pacioli's *De Scripturis*' 151.
27. See Alberto Bisaschi 'The accounting system of the Venerable Society of the Living and the Dead of Parma in medieval times' *Accounting History* 8 (2003) 89–111 at 104, 106–107.
28. Raymond de Roover 'The Account Book of Collard de Marke' *Bulletin of the Business Historical Society* 12 (1938) 44–7 at 45.

29. The verb *clareren* has quite a range of meanings, including 'declare, prove, clarify, purify, to make shiny'. The Middle English *declaren* means, amongst other things, 'to tell, enumerate, set down, explain, resolve, pass judgement on, reveal, display, discover'. However, spellings with *e* indicate that there may have been contamination with *cler*, meaning 'shining, bright, pure, lucid, clarified, glorious, excellent'; *maken cler*, for instance, means 'to glorify'. Such an overlap would make the Middle English verb similar in terms of semantic range to the Middle Dutch verb.
30. In the Dutch *Naeprologhe* ('After Prologue') there is no further reference to the object but instead the deed is mentioned: *Arm Elckerlijc, hoe vaerdi dan | Ter rekenighen voer onsen Heere?* ('Poor Everyman, how will you then go to account before Our Lord?' 864–5).
31. This argument was most forcefully presented in Herman Pleij *De sneeuwpoppen van 1511: Literatuur en stadscultuur tussen middeleeuwen en moderne tijd* (Amsterdam: Meulenhoff, 1988).
32. Davidson, Walsh, and Broos *Everyman and Elckerlijc* 2.
33. The English leaves out the reference to fairs outside town. Conversely, there is a more obvious urban reference in *Everyman* when the protagonist asks Fellowship to 'comforte me tyll I come without the towne' (291); *Elckerlijc*'s request to *Ghezelschap* to accompany him on his deadly pilgrimage *tot voer die poerte* ('until the gate' 262) seems more metaphorical than geographical.
34. See Leonard Willems '*Elckerlyc*'-Studiën (The Hague: Nyhoff, 1934) 19.
35. There are no *sinnekens*, the evidence for the use of *togen* or *tableaux vivants* is limited, and the intricacies of rhyme which are such a prominent feature of sixteenth-century Rhetoricians' plays are absent from *Elckerlijc*. Even Ramakers, who is convinced that *Elckerlijc* is the work of a Rhetorician, admits that its rhyme scheme is uncommonly simple; *Mariken van Nieumeghen* 27–8. However, the rhyme scheme of Anthonis de Roovere's play *Quicumque vult salvus esse* (before 1482) is on the whole also the simple *aabb* and yet Anthonis de Roovere was one of the best and most famous Rhetoricians in the mid to late fifteenth century. The simplicity of *Elckerlijc*'s rhyme scheme is consequently of little use in determining the play's Rhetorician status.
36. *Elckerlijc* is unsuited as an answer to the question which was set as the topic for moral plays at the 1496 Antwerp competition; see also van Elslander xi. For research into fifteenth-century *landjuwelen*, see E. van Autenboer 'Een "landjuweel" te Antwerpen in 1496?' *Jaarboek De Fonteyne* 29 (1978–79), 125–49.
37. For the prohibition, see W.M.H. Hummelen 'Kamerspelers: professionele tegenspelers van de rederijkers' *Oud Holland* 110 (1996) 117–34 at 117–18. This article contains many more references where Rhetoricians are disdainful of professional actors and playwrights.

38. Hummelen 'Kamerspelers' 127.
39. The *Bliscappen* were performed in Brussels, *Van Nyuevont, Loosheit ende Practike: hoe sij Vrou Lortse verheffen* is linked with Antwerp, *Tspel vanden heiligen sacramente van der nyeuwver vaert* was performed in Breda, and *Quicunque vult salvus esse* was written by the Bruges rhetorician Anthonis de Roovere.
40. Davidson, Walsh, and Broos *Everyman and Elckerlijc* 7–8.
41. Kolve 'Everyman and the Parable of the Talents' 317.
42. *Des coninx summe* at https://www.dbnl.org/tekst/_con001coni01_01/.
43. It is not impossible that this text was influenced by *Elckerlijc* — lines such as *op een cort doet rekeninghe gheheel en al | Ick ben de doot* ('In short, make an account of all and sundry. I am Death' 399–400) and *laet mi doch hebben om mijn beraet | Te stellen mijn rekeninghe intricaet* ('Let me have some delay, to make my intricate account' 457–8) are certainly reminiscent. But the reference to Death's *crebben* (400, probably 'crib, trough') has been explained as implying the depiction of Death as a horseman which would seem to be dissimilar to the presentation of Death in the play. It is more likely that both texts use a similar concept than that there is direct borrowing. See http://www.dbnl.org/tekst/dale004gdeg01_01/dale004gdeg01_01_0011.php.
44. 'Vander hogher Salen' ('Concerning the High Room') in the van Hulthem manuscript, which is dated c. 1410; <http://www.dbnl.org/titels/titel.php?id=knib002diec01>. The last line reads *in wijste*.
45. http://www.dbnl.org/titels/titel.php?id=_boe007boec01.
46. <http://www.dbnl.org/titels/titel.php?id=dirc001tafe01>.
47. John Lydgate 'The Testament of Dan John Lydgate' in *The Minor Poems of John Lydgate Part One* edited H.N. MacCracken *EETS ES 107* (1911 for 1910) 329–62 at 337, lines 215–22; quoted Kolve 'Everyman and the Parable of the Talents' 318.
48. William Langland *The Vision of Piers Plowman, A Critical Edition of the B-Text Based on Trinity College Cambridge MS B.15.17* edited A.V.C. Schmidt (London: Dent, 2nd edition 1995) Passus 19, 194–7.
49. *Mirk's Festial: A Collection of Homilies* edited Theodor Erbe *EETS ES 95* (1905), *Prik of Conscience* edited James H. Morey (TEAMS; Kalamazoo: Medieval Institute Publications, 2012), '*Lancelot of the Laik*' and '*Sir Tristrem*' edited Alan Lupack (TEAMS; Kalamazoo: Medieval Institute Publications, 1994; reprinted 1997).
50. The earliest instance of *clear* with financial connotations from the *OED* is from *The Merchant of Venice* and refers to debts; the *MED* meanings are primarily 'to shine forth, illuminate, purify, clarify'.
51. *Een scone leeringe om salich te sterven* edited B. de Geus, J. van der Heijden, A. Maat, and D. den Ouden (Utrecht: H&S, 1985).